

C1 Communication Audit

Pillar	Communication	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	40-50 minutes	Group Size	4-15
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	None (foundation diagnostic exercise)	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Low communication scores, misalignment signals, frequent clarification requests, information not reaching the right people

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Unclear communication creates cognitive load. The brain expends energy decoding ambiguous messages, tracking information across fragmented channels, and filling gaps with assumptions. This consumes the same prefrontal cortex resources needed for decision-making, creativity, and collaboration. Chronic communication friction sustains low-level cortisol elevation, not enough to cause a visible stress response, but enough to erode focus and engagement over weeks.

When communication channels are mapped and clarified, cognitive load drops. The brain can allocate resources to productive work instead of information management. The act of auditing communication as a team also activates oxytocin pathways: collaborative problem-solving signals that the team is working together, not just alongside each other.

IF A TEAM MEMBER ASKS "WHY ARE WE DOING THIS?"

"We have multiple communication channels and no shared understanding of which ones work and which ones cause problems. This exercise maps what we actually have, identifies what's broken, and agrees on changes. It takes 45 minutes and saves us hours of confusion every week."

The Exercise

Phase 1: Channel Mapping (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Let's map every communication channel this team uses. I mean everything: email, Slack, Teams, meetings, hallway conversations, shared documents, phone calls, text messages. Write each one on a separate sticky note."

Collect all channels on the flipchart/Miro. Group duplicates. Most teams are surprised by the total count. Twelve to fifteen channels is common for a team of 6-8 people.

Phase 2: Effectiveness Rating (10 minutes)

For each channel, the team rates two things:

- Clarity: Does information arrive clear and complete through this channel? (1-5)
- Reliability: Does information actually reach who needs it? (1-5)

Use a quick show-of-hands or Mentimeter poll for each channel. Write the average scores on the board. Patterns emerge fast: most teams have 2-3 channels that score well and 4-5 that score poorly but persist because nobody has questioned them.

Phase 3: The Gap Diagnosis (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Now the important question. Looking at this map, where does information get lost? Not in theory. Think about the last two weeks. Where did something fall through the cracks? Where did someone not get information they needed? Where did you get information you didn't need?"

Capture specific examples, not abstract concerns. "Sarah didn't know about the deadline change because it was mentioned in a Slack channel she doesn't check" is useful. "Communication could be better" is not.

Phase 4: Two Changes (10 minutes)

The team selects exactly two changes to implement. Not five. Not ten. Two. Constraint forces prioritisation.

WHAT TO SAY

"We could fix everything, but we won't fix anything if we try to do it all at once. Looking at what we've mapped, what are the two changes that would make the biggest difference in the next two weeks? One thing we'll start doing differently and one thing we'll stop doing."

Write the two changes on a single card. Post it visibly. Review in two weeks.

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
The team blames specific people for communication failures	Redirect to systems: "Let's focus on the channels and processes rather than individuals. If information isn't reaching the right people, that's a system problem, not a person problem. What about the channel or process allowed this to happen?"
Everyone agrees communication is 'fine' despite CLOVER ERA data showing otherwise	Name the gap: "Our data shows communication is surfacing as a concern. That might mean the problems are invisible to us because we've adapted to them. Let me ask it differently: what's one communication frustration you've just accepted as normal?"
The audit surfaces too	This is why the two-change limit matters. "We've identified a lot. That's

many problems and the team feels overwhelmed	useful because now we can see the full picture. But we're not fixing all of this today. We're picking the two highest-impact changes and starting there."
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Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	The channel map surprises people ("I didn't realise we use that many channels") Specific examples of information gaps are shared freely The two-change selection generates genuine debate about priorities
Within 2 weeks	The team references the two changes in daily work At least one information gap is closed by the new approach Someone says "we agreed to use [channel] for this"
CLOVER ERA data (2-4 weeks)	Communication scores improve Misunderstood instructions and frequent clarification signals decrease
Red flags	If the two changes are forgotten within a week, the exercise produced agreement without commitment. Post the changes visibly and reference them in the next team meeting.

Remote/Hybrid Adaptation

Element	Remote Modification
Channel mapping	Use Miro sticky notes. The digital format is actually better here because it captures channels that only exist digitally.
Rating	Mentimeter or Miro voting dots. Faster than show-of-hands online.
Timing	Same duration. This exercise translates well to remote.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
C12: Over-Communication	C1 maps channels; C12 addresses overload within them. Run C1 first to identify which channels need C12 attention.	Run C1 before C12
C13: Asynchronous Communication	C1 often surfaces async issues. C13 provides the targeted fix.	Run C1 before C13

E9: Removing Outdated Processes	Communication channels are processes. Outdated ones identified in C1 feed into E9.	Complementary
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